to it that they were fit and relaxed as well. The stadium, where the meet was being held, bustled with great activity. Children from several schools were moving around checking out the different venues where particular events were to be held. Prakash Sir collected the schedule and gave the girls **appropriate** instructions. The Principal of the host school inaugurated the meet with a short speech and also introduced the participating schools. Then the events started. Rucha and most of the other children of their school easily got through the heats to enter the finals scheduled for the following day. The next morning, after a few individual events, it was time for the girls' relay race. Four schools had entered the finals. Rucha, Aruna, Shabnam and Neelam were Team B.

Prakash Sir gave them final words of encouragement.

"Girls, you are a good team. You can win! Go ahead and show your **mettle!** Good luck."

Shabnam, a tall girl, was their first runner. She would pass the baton to Neelam, Neelam would pass it to Aruna, and Aruna to Rucha, who would be finishing the race for them. The ***whistle*** blew and the first runners were off. With her long strides, Shabnam gave the team a marginal lead. But by the time Neelam had passed the baton to Aruna, both Team A and D had drawn level with her. Then, the runner of Team D fumbled and dropped the baton. Aruna ran for all she was worth, just managing to keep abreast of the runner of the Team A.



Finally, the baton was in Rucha's hand. She had already noted with dismay that she was pitted against 'P.T. Usha' of Team A. **'Just my luck.'** the thought had flashed through her mind. She had quickly put that thought aside, and when the baton was passed to her, she was more than ready. She heard the shouts of her schoolmates, "Rucha, come on! Ru...cha! Ru...cha!" Out of the corner of her eye, Rucha saw 'P.T. Usha' trying to overtake her.

FLEETINGLY, she thought, 'Not again!' Then Prakash Sir's words came to her: 'Think to win!' The next moment, Rucha was conscious of nothing except the tape at the finishing line which she had to reach. Totally absorbed, she ran, she lost track of time and distance.

She ran on, not conscious of the fact that the race was over till Aruna called out to

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